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What Does a Community Organizer Do?

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Community organizers advocate for a certain cause by organizing a group of people who share common goals. These professionals often focus on social and political topics and use communication skills to gather support for their position. If you are interested in this career path, it is helpful to understand the primary duties and skills of these professionals. In this article, we help you understand what community organizing is, the role of a community organizer and how to become one.

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What is community organizing?

A community organizer is an individual who networks with and mobilizes the community to support a cause, develops programs or initiates any other positive social impact. You can find employment as a community organizer in the government, churches, nonprofit organizations, health organizations, social services agencies and more. A community organizer can work in

various sectors like public housing, community development, social work and the nonprofit sector.

It is easier for the community organizer to help the community achieve solutions to their needs if they focus on specific objectives. A community organizer acts on people's right to come together to influence policies and advocate for their rights.

Community organizing is a process of mobilizing and empowering community members to identify their needs and collectively resolve them. The process also involves:

- Identifying the structures and people that can help the community achieve the appropriate solutions
- Negotiating with these people to solve the community's problems
- Establishing an institution that the community controls democratically with a purpose and capacity to face future problems

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What is the purpose of community organizing?

The main purpose of community organizing is to bring the community together to identify and solve their needs. It also serves other specific roles, including:

- Encouraging members of the community to be aware of their environment and situations
- Helping the members to realize their collective responsibility and ability to manage themselves and their environment sustainably
- Giving individuals an opportunity to participate in decisions and actions that affect them
- Strengthening the community's capacity to access funds internally and externally that will support the community's socio-economic projects
- Creating a platform for the community to form alliances that help with advocacy and sharing technology

- Facilitating the establishment of permanent and sustainable structures to manage the community's resources

What does a community organizer do?

Some of the daily duties of a community organizer include project planning, networking with other professionals and community members and creating informational material.

A community organizer's responsibilities often depend on the different stages of the community organizing process. A community organizer starting the process from scratch will have the following responsibilities as their community organizing process progresses:

1. Pre-entry or preparation stage

Community organizers have the following responsibilities in the pre-entry stage before they engage the community:

- Training and orientation for community organizing
- Making administrative preparations such as establishing a local office and hiring personnel
- Selecting a community-approved site to complete their work

2. Entry or integration phase

In the integration phase, the community organizer reaches out to the community to establish a relationship with mutual respect and trust. This phase is also known as grassroots action. Some of the community organizers' activities include:

- Using the communities livelihood and social activities to collect data
- Giving existing leaders courtesy calls
- Identifying, reaching out to and working with potential leaders
- Establishing a core group and networks to initiate the community organizing activities
- Recruiting members for the core group and the community organization as a whole

- Providing the core group with leadership training

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3. Community planning and implementation phase

Community organizers should engage in organizational planning and implementation after they network with a community. There are responsibilities in this stage related to organizational development, capacity building and training and resource management. Here are some of these primary duties:

- Recruiting members and building a team of organizers
- Developing the administration and management to support generation projects
- Registering the community organization with the relevant government authority to formalize the process and get accreditation
- Encouraging the community to take political action
- Managing any conflict that may occur between team or community members
- Organizing study tours
- Training to handle sensitive topics
- Proposing and engaging in activities that enhance the resources, such as setting up wildlife sanctuaries

4. Strengthening the community organization

The community organization needs to be strengthened to achieve sustainability. It involves activities like:

- Building alliances and networking with other organizations
- Consolidating the organization's operating procedures, such as the various committees' functions, the organization structure, policies for membership and more

- Training volunteers and leaders to do the work
- Accessing resources and strengthening social, economic services
- Monitoring resource enhancement measures

5. Monitoring and Evaluation

The community organizers and the organization need to track the goals, objectives, mission and vision. Therefore, they will use monitoring which is periodically assessing the projects to measure progress. Community organizers also use the evaluation process, which helps assess how successful the implementation of the community plans has been. The roles and responsibilities of community organizers in the monitoring and evaluation stage include:

- Assessing the progress of a project against its objectives
- Distributing community organizing reports
- Giving timely and appropriate recommendations on changes

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6. Phase-Out Stage

The phase-out stage is the last stage of community organizing. The community organizer usually withdraws from the community once they achieve their goals and prove sustainable. There are situations where the community organizer and supporting organization remain present for the long run. The community runs the various programs and only go to the community organizer for technical guidance or assistance. Activities in the phase-out stage include:

- Managing the goals, volunteers and staff of the organization
- Handing over to community members if the project proves sustainable
- Carrying out monitoring and evaluation

Community organizer skills

A community organizer may need the following skills to execute their duties and responsibilities effectively:

- Leadership
- Interpersonal
- Public speaking
- Community engagement
- Research
- Analytical and cognitive
- Reporting
- Listening
- Communication
- Time management
- Critical thinking and problem-solving
- Advocacy
- Management
- Self-awareness
- Multitasking
- Computer and phone

Community organizer job requirements

The following are examples of some of the requirements you may need to meet to find employment as a community organizer:

- **Formal training:** Though it is not always required, formal training helps you prepare for your professional responsibilities. It is sometimes helpful to have a background in social work, social justice sociology or other social services.
- **Volunteer experience:** A background of volunteering with social organizations provides practical learning that helps you understand the policies for social change better.
- **Teamwork:** The ability to work with other professionals as a team helps you accomplish your goals and grow your organization.
- **Understanding of community organizing:** A competent understanding of community organizing processes, concepts and development theories helps you create organizational strategies.

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Community organizer work environment

Community organizers can work for various entities, including the government, churches, nonprofit organizations, public health departments and social services agencies. You can choose to work in specific departments like public health departments, public housing, social work and community development.

The working conditions of a community organizer depend on where you work. You may need to live with minimum amenities, especially in developing communities. You should also try to communicate effectively with the members of the community to make your work easier.

Community organizing can take about a year to several years. It is a process so its objectives and the entire process have a time limit. The time frame depends on the objectives the community sets with the help of a community organizer and support agency.

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